

Reckoner

of Marc Garneau C.I.

MGCI SAC

PROGRESS REPORT

THE RECKONER ASSEMBLED A BREAKDOWN OF THE FOLLOWING SAC MEMBERS' PERFORMANCES USING THEIR 2014-2015 CAMPAIGN PROMISES AND INTERVIEWS CONDUCTED BY OUR STAFF.

GOALS ACHIEVED OR PROMISES FULFILLED

PRESIDENT

MARIA KASHIF

COMPETITIONS AND ACTIVITIES PROMOTED SCHOOL SPIRIT, INCLUDING THE TERRY FOX FUNDRAISER, AND THE DONUT EATING CONTEST.

EXTERNAL GRANTS FUNDED THE GARNEAU MOSAIC, A BOOK TO CELEBRATE THE DIVERSITY WITHIN STUDENTS AT GARNEAU

HOST A HOMECOMING BASH FOR STUDENTS IN SEPTEMBER

CHAIRPERSON

RICHARD WU

HELPED CREATE SAC INFOGRAPHIC

BRIDGED GAP BETWEEN STUDENT BODY AND SAC WITH SURVEY PROGRAM

ENCOURAGE SAC TO PUSH THROUGH DECISIONS BEYOND REALM OF COUNCIL

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS OFFICER

ASHIFA HUDANI

UNIQUE NEW DESIGN FOR SCHOOL SWEATER

ATTENDED SUPERCOUNCIL, PARENT COUNCIL, AND ALUMNI MEETINGS

FEW CAMPAIGN PROMISES MADE

TREASURER

MUSTAFA BANDUKWALA

CREATED CRITERIA LIST FOR FAIR ALLOCATION OF CLUB FUNDS

COORDINATED WITH CLUBS TO MAKE SURE CASH BOXES WERE PROPERLY ALLOCATED

ONE-SEMESTER DELAY IN IMPLEMENTING EQUITABLE CLUB FUNDS

SPECIAL EVENTS CONVENER

SAMRIN QUADER

CHEAPER INTERNATIONAL SHOW TICKETS

SMALL SCALE EVENTS TO CELEBRATE DIVERSITY

CULTURAL PERFORMANCES THROUGHOUT THE YEAR

SOCIAL JUSTICE AND EQUITY REP

JACKIE HO

HELPED LINK SAC AND RECKONER

RAISED AWARENESS ABOUT GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE AND HOMOPHOBIA

LACK OF PARTICIPATION IN SOCIAL JUSTICE AND EQUITY COMMITTEE

COMMUNICATIONS COORDINATOR

MAHAD KHOKAR

ORGANIZED OUTREACH COMMITTEE

REGULARLY UPDATED SOCIAL MEDIA TO KEEP STUDENTS UPDATED ON VARIOUS EVENTS

ORGANIZED THE NEW SE- MESTER ELECTION PROCESS

FAILED TO REVAMP SCHOOL WEBSITE TO MAKE IT MORE USER-FRIENDLY

PROMISES THAT WERE NOT FULFILLED OR COULD NOT BE OBJECTIVELY ASSESSED

VICE PRESIDENT

ARORA CHEN

COLLABORATED AND ENCOURAGED SAC TO PARTICIPATE IN CLUB-LED EVENTS

WORKED CLOSELY WITH AND ASSISTED PRESIDENT

HELP STUDENTS ORGANIZE THEIR OWN EVENTS

CLUBS CONVENER

AURTHEYSH AMARANATH

CREATED BUZZ BOARD WITH A LIST OF ALL CLUBS AND RESPECTIVE MEETING TIMES

HELP NEW CLUBS FIND STAFF SUPERVISORS

SOCIAL CONVENER

LYDIA GOUVEIA

CREATED ONLINE FORUM FOR SEMI

WINTER BALL AND SPRING FLING CANCELLED DUE TO LACK OF INTEREST

ATHLETIC CONVENER

MICHELLE NYAMEKYE

REINTRODUCED ATHLETIC FEE TO PROVIDE A CHEAPER ATHLETIC BANQUET

RAN VOLLEYBALL IN TRAMURALS (WASNT POSSIBLE DURING THE 2013-2014 SCHOOL YEAR)

MORE SPIRIT DURING HOME GAMES

EQUITY REPRESENTATIVE

HAMZA SHAHID

HOSTED SEVERAL SPOKEN WORD CAFES

PLANNED FUNDRAISERS: GIVE DIRECTLY, CLOTHING DRIVE FOR NEW CIRCLES, ETC.

INCORPORATE STUDENT IDEAS INTO FUNDRAISERS

SPIRIT CONVENER

MARA GAGIU

UPCOMING PEP RALLY WITH EVENTS INCLUDING ARM WRESTLING AND MUSICAL CHAIRS

HOSTED SEVERAL SCHOOL SPIRIT EVENTS, INCLUDING RED NOSE CAMPAIGN, SUCCESSFUL CHRISTMAS SHOW, HALLOWEEN FASHION SHOW

MONTHLY GRADEWIDE COMPETITIONS OR EXCURSIONS

GRAD CONVENER

GLORIA ZHOU

LOWERED PROM TICKETS BY \$10

MAKING SENIOR'S FAREWELL VIDEO

PROMOTION OF PROM

PRODUCED BY

the Reckoner

of Marc Garneau C.I.

What is SHSM?

by DEIFILIA TO

Students compete in the annual Skills Canada competition. Photo: Sophia Liu

This year, The Reckoner decided to take a closer look at three specialized programs the school has to offer: TOPS, BSAP, and SHSM. Each program is catered towards a different group of students, each unique in their respective ways. We sought to explore more about each program, and discovered the unique history behind them.

The Specialist High Skills Major (SHSM) program first became available to Garneau students in 2009.

SHSM is offered in many high schools across Ontario. In most schools, the program begins in Grade 11. Students who complete the program graduate with a High School Diploma embossed with a SHSM seal. These diplomas are widely recognized in post-secondary institutions across Ontario. There are nine required courses to graduate: 4 Major credits in technology – two Grade 11 and two Grade 12 credits

- 1 Math credit in Grade 11
- 1 English Credit in Grade 12
- 1 Art, business, or science credit in either Grade 11 or 12
- 2 Co-op credits in Grade 11 or 12

SHSM seeks to equip students with the skills, knowledge, and experience to help them thrive in post-secondary institutions, apprenticeships, or the workplace. There currently exist nineteen sectors within SHSM, including Agriculture, Forestry, Hospitality and Tourism, and Transportation.

The focus at MGCI is on information communications technology (ICT). This sector gives students the skills to effectively process information using electronic systems. They are taught critical concepts

pertaining to design and development, sales and marketing, security, and presentation skills.

Aside from the high school credit courses, SHSM contains other components, including:

- Sector-recognized certification and training
- Reach ahead activities
- Dual credits
- Competitions

In most schools across Ontario, SHSM is only open to Grade 11 and 12 students. However, MGCI received special permission from the Ministry of Education to allow Grade 9 and 10 students to participate in the SHSM program. When the students enter Grade 11, they become SHSM students. Everything pertaining to SHSM that is accomplished in Grade 9 and 10 will be entered on their Grade 11 SHSM records. This allows students to fast-track courses, opening up more spaces on their timetables for elective courses to be taken.

In addition to the required courses, students must also complete six sector-recognized certification and training programs. Three are compulsory: CPR Level A, Standard First Aid, and a WHMIS course. On top of these three standardized certifications, MGCI offers five other training programs, of which students must complete three.

Each certification is paid for by the Ministry of Education, allowing full accessibility to everyone. The CPR course is offered to students as a day-long activity during Winterfest. The rest are completed throughout the school year.

Reach Ahead is offered specifically to SHSM students. Students are taken on

tours of universities and colleges in the GTA. The trips are held throughout the year, and run on a first-come-first-serve basis. Typically, there are 46 spots open per trip. Students tour the facilities and classrooms of the universities and colleges. Throughout the years, MGCI has visited Ryerson University, OCAD, Sheridan, and Centennial College.

SHSM students also have the opportunity to study in a college level course. This is done while the student is taking co-op. One day out of every week is spent attending class, rather than working in their co-op placement. In their first year of post-secondary education, students can then skip the respective course, saving a substantial amount of money. This gives students an advantage when applying for university or college. By having a college credit with a good mark on the credit counseling sheet, students are effectively showing the universities their experience and competence.

Students in older grades are encouraged to participate in skills competitions. This year, MGCI hosted the Skills Canada Competition, inviting several schools to participate. Garneau performed well, with gold awards in three categories, silver in two, bronze in one, and an honourable mention for high scores in one.

Though these competitions are targeted towards SHSM students, any Garneau student who has taken a technology course in the respective area of competition can participate.

Ultimately, students who participate in SHSM benefit from the hands-on experience they obtain. While high school is a place for students to gain knowledge and understanding of concepts, it often lacks in providing the opportunity to apply knowledge in practical ways. SHSM teaches students how to present their ideas with professionalism. It helps them use media screens, websites, and print effectively, skills that are applicable in almost any career.

Mr. Welch, a teacher at Marc Garneau, is the lead teacher who currently runs the program, with assistance from Mr. Seenath, Mr. Jan, and Ms. Warren. Before the SHSM program existed at the school, Mr. Welch and Mr. Seenath were approached by the Ministry of Education. The Board had approached the two teachers in hopes of starting up the ICT sector in the school.

See SHSM on P4

Teacher Feature:

Ms Balkissoon

by SHEILA BALU

Due to space constraints, this interview has been abridged. The full conversation can be found online.

Q: What subjects do you teach at this school?

A: I have taught here presently science and English and biology. I also teach chemistry and math. So you never know, you can catch me in all subjects at all times.

Q: What inspires you to teach?

A: I really like teaching. I really like the interaction between the students and the teachers. At this level in high school you actually get students who have opinions about things, who are actually informed on some things, and can challenge you on things, and I like that. By having a different group of students all the time means every day is different. Every day is interesting. I really like that. When I was in school and I was doing my science degree, I really liked science but I didn't want to go further with that. I wanted to do something that still included science, and always liked kids, so I thought teaching would be a good fit for me. And it has been.

See BALKISSOON on P4

Fight Back Against Cancer

The MGCI Cancer Society sold samosas, Freezies, and pop, raising over \$100 in food sales alone. Photo: Jackie Ho.

by REBECCA WONG

On 25 May 2015, students at MGCI showed their support for the fight against cancer by participating in the annual Relay for Life event. It was organized by the MGCI Cancer Society, with help from Mr. Persaud and Mrs. Cheryl Chan. The fundraising event was held to remember those who lost their lives to cancer, celebrate the lives of cancer survivors, and to fight against cancer. Relays are hosted in communities all across Canada, with proceeds going to the Canadian Cancer Society for cancer research and patient support programs.

Fundraising began in April with

daffodil sales, which extended into May. In addition, participants had to fundraise at least \$30 for the event, which included the registration fee. The student who fundraised the highest amount this year was Grade 10 student Jessica Fung, who collected \$330. The fundraising during this year's Relay for life event consisted mainly of food sales in the cafeteria all day. Samosas were sold for \$0.75, or three for \$2, freezies were sold for \$0.25 or three for \$1, and pop was sold for \$1.

See RELAY on P4

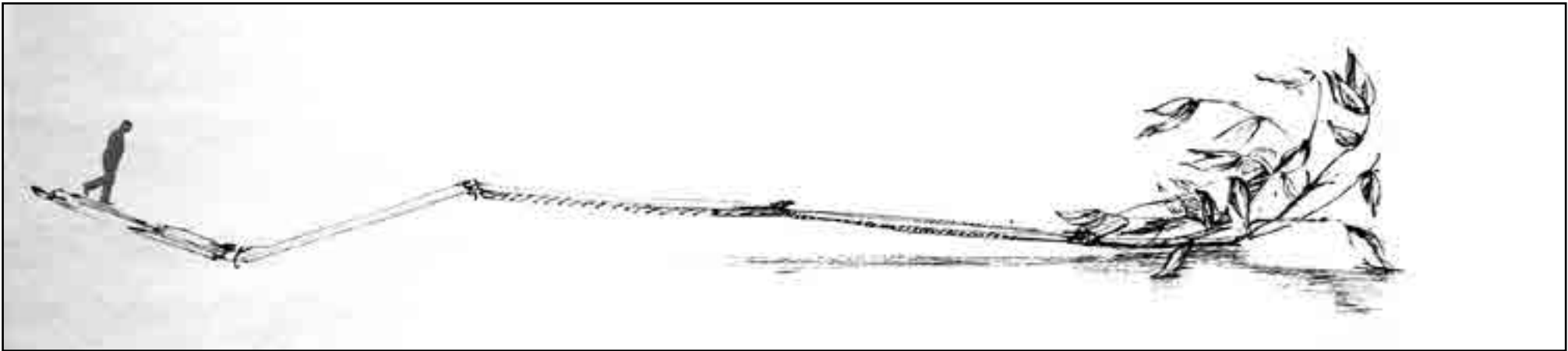
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www.thereckoner.ca



Taking a Walk

by YILIN ZHU



We are (not) awake

by XIN NIU ZHANG

Look,
Here are the girls in flannel
Lanky and alone.

Look at the rust crusting their elbows
(Scraped raw)
The rust around the corners of their grins
(All carved out)
The rust and spit in their sighs
And on the songs they breathe

They sing,
“Let them forget me.”

Look,
Here is a map
To the jigsaw of blood and breaks
And bluffs
On their rust red lips

Look,
Here is the sheet music
To that yawning cacophony of hope and hate and hurt in
their voices
And in the slouching shape of their shoulders.

Well. Look again.

Because we are not
hurt;

Because this is not a
bluff;

Who is forcing you to look a w a y ?

Look,
There go the girls in flannel
Lanky and alone.

They sing,
“Let them damn me.”

The Unending Cycle

by LILA HUANG



The Unfortunate Lady

by MOUJAN SADERI

There once was a gray old woman,
who lived on Hickory Lane.
Her house was pink with purple stripes,
and one lime green window pane.

But what made her house peculiar,
was not the strange decor.
It was the garden, blooming bright,
with plants and trees galore.

Orange pumpkins, and strawberry shrubs,
growing between the towering trees.
A disorganized tangle of bushes and vines,
happy flowers and ferns for the bees.

A cactus hiding in the shade of a palm,
patches of wheat swaying in the breeze.
A single proud stalk of ripened corn,
cabbages among the roots of the trees.

The garden seemed like a magical place,
with secrets hidden among the leaves.
It left her neighbors wondering,
what tricks the lady had up her sleeves.

One morning a brave little schoolgirl,
marched up to the lady's front door.
Her curiosity had grown so large—
She couldn't stand it any more!

The girl needed to know how a garden,
could grow such wonderful things.
Did the lady use soil from enchanted lands?
Or water from exotic springs?

The hefty door creaked as it opened,
the girl's heart began to pound,
two green eyes peeked out and a timid voice
asked:
“Ummm hello... What brings you around?”

The girl immediately blurted out:
“It's your garden! It's just so strange.”
She saw the lady's eyes grow cold,
as her expression began to change.

A moment passed in silence,
the girl's knees went shaky and weak,
the old lady took a deep breath,
and then she began to speak.

“I planted the seeds of pumpkins,
but cabbages grew instead.
When I planted onions, a rose bush appeared,
with flowers blooming a beautiful red.

I wanted some berries, to bake into pie,
but a pear tree sprouted and grew.
And a cactus somehow appeared in my yard,
when I wanted carrots to make into stew.

I bury the seeds of one plant,
and another plant grows in its place!
But this doesn't just happen when gardening...
Tears streamed down the lady's face.

“This morning I wanted a sandwich,
I cut myself a slice of cheese,
but when I placed it onto the bread,
it became a portion of fleas!

I cracked open an egg, and out poured sham-
poo,
my bagel turned into a sandal,
and when I sat on my couch to take a break,
it became a giant door handle.

One time I placed a bowl into the kitchen sink,
and it suddenly caught on fire,
the purple flames spread across the counter,
coconut scented smoke rose higher.

I picked up the phone to call for help,
but it became an angry goose.
I kicked the table in anger,
and it turned into mango juice.”

The girl exploded in laughter,
turning red as she waved goodbye.
As the old lady watched her walk away,
the only thing she could do was cry.

What Makes it Ultimate

by SHEILA BALU

“So, do you play any sports?”
“Yeah! Our Ultimate Frisbee season just
started las—”
“No, I meant like, *real* sports.”
If you've walked past Garneau's list of clubs
and sports in the hallway, you probably didn't
even notice that Ultimate isn't on the list. Tell
someone you play Ultimate, and you'll proba-
bly get a laugh and an intervention, since Fris-
bees are clearly only for dogs. Explain to your
teacher how you're missing the class for an Ul-
timate tournament, and you might get a weird
look and a response around the lines of “Wow,
kids actually do that these days?” As you tear-
fully watch your teacher wish the soccer play-
ers good luck from afar, you just can't help but
wonder why the haters have to hate so much.

Despite the fact that we live in a 'progres-
sive' society, people seem to have the general
opinion that Ultimate Frisbee is not a legiti-
mate sport. True, it's not an Olympic sport. But
it should be. Are you one of those people who
think that it would be silly to add Ultimate to
the Olympics? Since solo synchronized swim-
ming, pigeon shooting, club swinging, and rope
climbing have all been Olympic sports at some
point, at least you won't have to worry about
Ultimate being the silliest. Watching people sky
and layout is probably more interesting than
watching a swimmer synchronize with, um,
him- or herself.

There are many stereotypes associated with
Ultimate players that need to be disproved.
Contrary to popular belief, Ultimate isn't just
played by left-wing stoner hippies. A Republi-
can once played in 1992 and said it was, and
I quote, “pretty cool.” Not all players are ex-
troverted World of Warcraft players, boys who
are over six feet tall but also under 130 pounds,
or various other demographics that are too
faint-hearted for rugby. These assumptions are

false; there are in fact boys who weigh 131.
Cool people don't play Ultimate, right? Tell
that to Joel Silver, who invented the sport in
New Jersey in 1968. He went on to film numer-
ous action movies including the Matrix, the Die
Hard series, and Sherlock Holmes. Meh, never
heard of them.

Some see Ultimate simply as a glorified game
of toss. After all, adding the prefix 'ultimate' to
a toy can't possibly make it cooler, can it? Ul-
timate ping-pong. Ultimate baseball. Ultimate
volleyball. Nope, they just don't have the same
ring to it. In all seriousness though, Ultimate
players make some of the best athletes in the
world. Playing for over an hour, many easily run
ten kilometres in a single game, rivaling that of
even soccer. It's undeniable that Ultimate play-
ers have crazy hops and more layouts than in
any other game. It's also an exciting, fast-paced
mental exercise, as between points you have to
read the wind, analyze the other team's tactics,
and accordingly set up the best offensive and
defensive position within the blink of an eye.

Perhaps people underestimate Ultimate
simply because they don't know how to play.
In a nutshell, it has all the excitement of foot-
ball, minus the off-field abuse and dogfighting.
Frisbees are also less prone to Defatigate ac-
tivities, which is an additional plus. If you want
to layout, simply pretend to be Superman and
horizontally soar towards the disc. It's all about
commitment.

A widespread complaint is that Ultimate is
too friendly because it usually doesn't involve
fighting. Yes, Ultimate is a non-contact sport,
but you evidently haven't seen the face of a guy
who just got hit between the legs with a 'stray'
disc. Or the girl who mistakenly assumed that
her chest would cushion her spectacular end-
zone layout. There's also always at least one guy
on the field who gets confused and tries to catch

the disc with his face. Good enough?
Definitely not. The most distinctive part
of Ultimate that makes it stand out from oth-
er sports is its sportsmanship. It's centred
around a holistic view known as “the Spirit of
the Game.” A real Ultimate match has no refer-
ees; the players go by an honor system and are
trusted to contest their own fouls and outs. In
the end, it results in a commitment to fairness,
mutual respect of the other team's skills, and—
above all—having a good time. Being ‘spirited’
is seen as a goal in itself.

Still need proof that Ultimate is nothing to
be looked down upon? Just Youtube Brodie
Smith's Greatest Game of HORSE, and you'll
never pick up a basketball again. There are oth-
er additional perks too, namely that it's an in-
credibly accessible sport. All you need is a Fris-
bee and some friends, the former being cheap
and easy to find. Although you may blatantly
deny it, you probably already own one: there
have been more Frisbees sold than footballs,
baseballs, and basketballs combined. Every-
thing else you like is probably either addictive,
illegal, fattening, expensive, or impossible any-
ways.

In the end, it all comes down to passion.
There isn't a feeling in the world that compares
to chasing down a long pass, sprinting as fast
as you can, diving and catching it on the tip of
your fingers. Ultimate is exhilarating. Ultimate
rewards persistence and hard work by uniting
players on the field. Ultimate is more than a
group of people chasing a squashed piece of
plastic. Ultimate is unique, powerful, and in-
credible in every way.

So this summer, try picking up a disc. Let the
haters hate, and just shake it off. And you might
realize just how hucking awesome Ultimate is. ■



MGCI's Annual Popularity Contest

by DANIEL PEKAR

You walk into the galleria on the first
day of student council elections and
are bombarded with posters. They
scream “VOTE FOR ME” and display
catchy slogans involving candidates’
names. 39 candidates and a cap of 60
posters each means that we have 2000
posters plastering the walls of the first
floor for a week until they are inevita-
bly recycled. These posters never give
any information on what candidates
actually plan to do because there is no
need for them to; students do not find
platforms important when deciding
whom to vote for. So while there are
many important factors when it comes

to winning a SAC election, a good plat-
form is not one of them. Here's a little
guide on all you need to have a chance
at getting into student council:

Do you know what your position
does? Irrelevant as long as you have a
large enough group of friends! Don't
have a real platform? Just make a few
vague sentences about “bringing the
school together” and how important
equality and unity are without actu-
ally saying what you plan to do. That
should be good enough. Worried about
speeches? Don't be, all you need to do
is shout-out to your friends, make a
few provocative poses, or drop a few

rhymes. After all, we all know rappers
make the best treasurers. There is no
need for anything of substance. And
don't forget, it's all about your per-
sonality and appearance, so now is a
good time to take out those modelling
photos and learn Photoshop. Now,
you know you want to get into student
council, but not sure of any specific
reason? Just say it is because you want
the power and authority that comes
with it.

In the presidential debate between
Arora Chen and Ejay Vidad, I asked
what SAC plans to do to increase in-
formed voting and discourage popu-
larity voting. They responded by say-
ing that you can't “force information
on students and expect them to retain
it” and also that “popularity contests
are going to be happening everywhere,
in any election ... that's just how the
world works.” Basically, neither can-
didate has any plans on actually ad-
dressing this problem. The mentality
is that if we cannot fix the problem
then we should not even try.

This problem of students being
voted in based on their popularity is
one that boils down to how elections
are organized. Marc Garneau's elec-
tions are about posters which do not
have any real information on them,
speeches which are about who can
hype up the crowd, or who has the best
sunglasses, or the best rap. Speeches
might have a few vague lines about
what might happen, but no concrete
ideas. This current system where stu-
dents can get away with being apathet-

ic is detrimental to student council, as
there is no guarantee that elected can-
didates are even remotely dedicated to
their positions. Student council needs
to alter how elections are run.
What can SAC do to try to fix this
problem? Decrease the cap on posters
per person, and have them be in des-
ignated poster spots. This way candi-
dates are forced to show who has bet-
ter ideas, rather than who can push out
more posters. Secondly, there should
be a spot for candidates to put up their
platforms so students can compare. As
of when this article was written there
have been about 170 unique visitors to
The Reckoner's SAC candidates over-
view page. Having them physically
presented in the school would increase
platform visibility. Finally, remove the
speeches which provide no real sub-
stance in the first place. Instead, have
a few people read out the candidates’
policies, or potentially have a small-
er version of the presidential debate
on stage. Finally, on the voting page,
along with the candidate's name and
face, have them put summarized notes
of their ideas, so that students can
compare them even during the voting
stage.

In elections, you are not voting
for pretty faces on colourful posters,
nor clever raps instead of intelligent
speeches on stage. You are voting for
platforms, policies, and ideas. The stu-
dent council election should not be a
glorified prom king/queen competi-
tion. ■



Illustration: Joy Wang

The Public Promposal

OP-ED by SUSIE LIU

If you're in the middle of planning an
elaborate public promposal to woo
that amazing prom date, stop now.
If you've already endured the ordeal,
my condolences. You might be ask-
ing, who is this party pooper to come
and rain on my prom parade? Give me
just a few hundred words to make my
appeal for a more private, subdued
promposal affair.

To start off, the publicity and ex-
travagance of a promposal in front of
a crowd may be off-putting for some.
The attention may be troubling for
your promposée, or it may even be
perceived as insincere – is this show
for the promposée, or is it primarily
for the onlookers? There is a classic
anecdote that the Japanese novel-
ist Natsume Soseki once advised his
students that “I love you” should be
translated into Japanese as “the moon
is beautiful”. It's a subtler and classier
way to express emotion, implying that
the moon is beautiful because you're
appreciating it with a special person.
A guy in your calculus class might be
kind of confused, however, if you tap
him on the shoulder and tell him that
the moon is beautiful, so you should
probably be a bit more direct than
that.

Additionally, a public prompos-
al introduces anxiety and unknown
variables into an already complex
and potentially disastrous affair. It's
already pretty terrifying to ask some-
one to be your date before you invite
their friends to watch on and evaluate
your performance. In addition, prom-
posing publicly introduces dynamic
and unpredictable quantities, such as
the volume level and airflow pattern
of a hallway. These cannot be planned



Illustration: Lila Huang

Elections: D-Day

EDITORIAL CARTOON by JEFFREY LIU





Relay For Life Runs at MGCI

RELAY
Continued from P1

During the lunch hour, approximately six teachers, four students, and a volunteer walked around the track to show their contributions to the fight against cancer.

Originally, the event was supposed to be held throughout the entire day, with food sales continuing in the back field after lunch. In addition, events for registered participants were supposed to run from 4:00pm to 8:00pm, but due to a lack of forms handed in on time, the afternoon portion was cancelled.

The event was supposed to include an opening ceremony, cancer survivors as guest speakers, and a luminary ceremony where participants could reflect on their reasons for supporting the fight against cancer. One of the highly advertised activities was bubble soccer, with participants playing soccer while inside inflated balls. Students were to be placed in teams, with a member from each team walking around the track throughout the afternoon.

Despite the setbacks in the organization of the event, Relay for Life was still successful in its efforts to raise awareness of the fight against cancer. Although the club's fundraising goal was \$2500, they raised \$1200 for cancer research, with approximately \$900 from the event itself. This figure includes both the money raised from food sales, and money fundraised by participants.

For Dorothy Qian, Junior President of the MGCI Cancer Society and Event Chair for this year's Relay for Life, this event is important because it not only "raises awareness for cancer, but also creates an united spirit to fight cancer. Cancer doesn't discriminate, so we're all affected, and we need to work together to fight it."

The Reckoner Wins Twelve Awards at High School Newspaper Competition



Photo: Parnika Godkhindi

by KAARTHIC PULOGARAJAH

On 21 May 2015, The Reckoner was cordially invited to the Toronto Star's printing press for its outstanding success in the Toronto Star High School Newspaper Awards. A competition that has been ongoing for 19 years, the Star's High School Newspaper Awards are presented to the best writing pieces or newspaper designs in 21 categories.

Students were given a tour of the printing facilities, and introduced to the different operations performed by the facility to consistently print the daily newspaper. After lunch, students were addressed by the Star's life editor Mary Vallis and reporter Tara Deschamps who inspired students to pursue reporting by recounting the unforgettable and life changing experiences they were exposed to in the field. After the speeches, the authors of the best submissions handpicked from a selection of nearly 600 entries were presented with their awards for achieving journalistic excellence, with many destined for The Reckoner of Marc Garneau.

The Reckoner won 12 awards in 10 different categories:

Reporting – Runner-up: Takhliq Amir

Feature Writing-Short – 1st Place: Bill Xun

Critical Writing – 1st Place: Xin Niu Zhang

Critical Writing – Runner-up: Lauren Chang

Editorial Writing – 1st Place: Parnika Godkhindi

Editorial Writing – Runner-up: Boshen Cui

Opinion Writing – 1st Place: Susie Liu

Editorial Cartoon – 1st Place: Cathy Zhang

Illustration – 1st Place: Ananna Rafa

Layout & Design, Page – Runner-up: Shela Qiu

Electronic Newspaper, Layout & Design, Special Feature Page – Runner-up: David Lu

Best Electronic Newspaper – 1st Place: The Reckoner Staff

Life is What You Bake It

BALKISSOON
Continued from P1



Ms. Balkissoon, pictured on right. Photo courtesy of Zaid Baig.

Q: If you could be any teacher in this school, who would it be and why?
A: I would be Ms. Paveling because she works with the food all day. I love food, and that would allow me to snack continuously during the day. And make awesome cupcakes.

Q: What's a pet peeve that you have?
A: I have so many pet peeves, I could answer this question all day. One of my biggest pet peeves is when you go to a fast food restaurant, and someone takes 10 minutes to order. Are you kidding me? The food hasn't changed! McDonald's has the same stuff every day, don't lie and tell me you want something different. Just get out of my line. Just get your food and get out.

Q: You really like food, don't you?
A: I'm all about the food.

Q: What do you want your students to take away from your lessons, especially in a non-academic context?
A: Critical thinking skills. As in, learn how to solve a problem. It doesn't matter what the problem is or what the answer to the problem is, but learn some sort of thought processes to get you through it. Figure out what you're trying to find out and then find out a way to get it. Think outside the box, something creative. That's what I want them to get out of it.

Q: What's the best gift you've ever been given?

A: If I say chocolate, are we back to the food again? [laughs] No, I got a bookmark. The bookmark was carved, it was out of a polymer, or acrylic or something. And it had my name on it, the school I was working at, and it had all these cool little biology designs. It was really nice, it was personalized, and it was a unique gift so it was really nice.

Q: Would you rather have a pet kangaroo or a pet llama?
A: Definitely the kangaroo. Kangaroos are cool. They can bounce, they can kick, they can fight, they put their babies in their pockets and they run around with them. A llama is just going to spit at me all day. And the babies are called joeys, that's just fun!

Q: Are you a night owl or an early riser?
A: Oh my god, I'm a night person! A hundred percent! Don't speak to me before noon, please. I never want to get up, I never want to come to school at 8:15 to teach first period. I'm always awake from midnight until whenever I can stay up. School needs to start after lunchtime for me.

Q: If you could give a piece of advice to a Garneau student, what would it be?
A: Be true to you. Do what you want to do, do what makes you happy. And I'm hoping that doesn't include smoking drugs and skipping school. What I mean is that when you choose your courses, don't let others influence you too much, like this is the best course for you. Maybe it's not. Maybe you know what it is that you like and where you want to go. The same thing with university and college: do what you think is going to be the best thing for you. I know it's hard for you guys to choose on your own when you're so young. But I feel like a lot of people get pushed in the wrong directions and then they end up being unsuccessful, and that's not our goal, right? We want every student to be successful in whatever it is they want to do.

The Sitch on SHSM

SHSM
Continued from P1

Both teachers have had substantial experience in the field; Mr. Welch has twenty-five years of experience in advertising, and Mr. Seenath has thirty in printing.

One student graduated from the SHSM program in 2009, the first year it began. Since then, the numbers have increased significantly, with nine, sixteen, and ten graduates respectively in 2012, 2013, and 2014.

One of the fundamental values behind the program is its openness to students. To register, students must simply speak to a Guidance or Technology teacher to acknowledge that they would like to participate in the program. This ensures that everybody has an equal opportunity to participate in a specialized program.

As such, the program is open to all Garneau students, including those in TOPS or BSAP. However, due to the demanding nature of the TOPS program, it is extremely difficult for students to complete the required courses in order to graduate from both programs. Only one student, Anna Xu, has completed both programs.

Though SHSM is one of the three specialized programs available in Garneau, it is arguably one of the least well known programs. The advertising tends to be limited to students who are taking technology classes. Each year, Mr. Welch also visits Valley Park, the feeder middle school across from MGCI, to promote the program to Grade 8 students.

One of the difficulties involved with participating in the program is the large time commitment involved. Unfortunately, failure to complete just one of the requirements for SHSM disallows students to graduate with the red seal. To remedy this issue, Mr. Welch came up with the Red Ribbon. This acknowledges students that completed a substantial part of the program, but was just shy of graduating with the necessary requirements.

Although SHSM has the potential to expand at Garneau, it is unlikely to do so in the near future. Organizing such a program requires a great deal of time commitment from teachers and administration.

Students who are in SHSM sign

up for various reasons. Gabeena Ahmad, a Grade 10 student, said that she joined because it would give her an advantage in her future academic career. Furthermore, she would recommend the program to other students because "it gives you many opportunities to shine and helps you stand out from the crowd".

Another Grade 10 SHSM student, Zaid Baig, said that he first heard about the program from a guidance counselor. Since joining, he has "mastered many skills in Media arts", which has allowed him to be more creative. He commented, "My favourite aspect of the program is that it allows you to have a real hands-on experience...It helps us develop to have a better understanding on many different aspects of the media industry."

The SHSM program allows any MGCI student to be in a special program that sets them above the crowd when applying for post-secondary institutions, apprenticeships or the workplace.



Photos by Cindy Cui

For more Humans of Garneau, visit bit.ly/GarneauHumans



"What makes you smile?"

"In general? Music. Guitar. You know what made me smile today? The weather."



"We were reading The Alchemist in class today and there was a quote I really liked."

"Do you still remember it?"

"When a person really desires something, all the universe conspires to help that person to realize his dream."

The Reckoner

of Marc Garneau C.I.

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